PurePy: A Functional Subset of Python

version 0.1.7

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PurePy is a pure functional subset of Python, providing a common functional language for use by researchers in programming languages and pedagogy, while providing a front-end familiar and accessible to the Python community. This specification defines a versioned standard with formal syntax, well-formedness rules based on a definite assignment analysis, and an operational semantics intended to preserve the meaning of well-formed PurePy programs in Python. By combining functional programming with Python-compatible surface syntax, PurePy aims to support portable implementations and lower-friction adoption of new language ideas for modelling, data processing, analysis, and visualisation.

1 Introduction

- Define subset of Python called PurePy, defined as a syntactic subset further restricted by a well-formedness predicate
- Define a semantics for PurePy such that the semantics of a PurePy program is identical to its semantics in Python
- Some well-formedness and evaluation rules could be given by a desugaring, but for now we avoid having two separate syntaxes

2 Syntax

To do:
- Reserved words
- Operators and precedence
- Recursion and mutual recursion
- Operational semantics of `if` statements
- Data classes and `match`

2.1 Contexts

Contexts Γ, Δ are partial functions from sets of variables to a *definite assignment* status in $\mathbb{B} = \{\mathsf{tt}, \mathsf{ff}\}$, with tt indicating *definitely assigned* and ff indicating *not definitely assigned*. The definite assignment terminology is borrowed from Java [7, §16]. (Or think of tt and ff as degenerate types "any" and "none".) It is useful to represent contexts as total functions from the set of all variables to $\mathbb{B}_\perp = \mathbb{B} \cup \{\perp\}$, with $\perp$ indicating *undefined*. We write $\Gamma, x : a$ for the context that sends x to a and otherwise agrees with Γ, define $\mathrm{dom}(\Gamma) = \{x \mid \Gamma(x) \neq \perp\}$, and write $\varnothing$ for the context where all variables are undefined.

Context operations. Contexts admit a non-commutative monoid of sequential composition $\Gamma \cdot \Delta$ ("override") and an idempotent commutative semigroup of parallel composition $\oplus$ ("merge"). Together these form a *right near-semiring* [28]: $\cdot$ right-distributes over $\oplus$ (Lemma 1), but left distributivity does not hold. Both operations are defined pointwise via operations on $\mathbb{B}_\bot$:

Definition 1 (Override and merge)**.** *For $a, b \in \mathbb{B}$:*

$$\begin{aligned} \bot \cdot b = b \cdot \bot = b \qquad & \qquad \bot \oplus \bot = \bot \\ a \cdot b = b \qquad & \qquad b \oplus \bot = \bot \oplus b = \mathsf{ff} \\ & \qquad a \oplus b = a \wedge b \end{aligned}$$

The $\cdot$ operation is right-biased and has $\bot$ as left and right unit. The $\oplus$ operation lacks a unit; when exactly one argument is defined, the result is ff; when both are defined, it returns the conjunction of their values in $\mathbb{B}$.

Lemma 1 (Right distributivity)**.**

$$(\Delta \oplus \Delta') \cdot \Gamma = (\Delta \cdot \Gamma) \oplus (\Delta' \cdot \Gamma).$$

Left distributivity ($\Gamma \cdot (\Delta \oplus \Delta') = (\Gamma \cdot \Delta) \oplus (\Gamma \cdot \Delta')$) does not hold. If it did, the following two programs would be equivalent, since sequential composition with a preceding assignment could be distributed into the branches of a conditional. But they are not: the left program is ill-formed, because a variable assigned before a conditional does not remain definitely assigned if only some branches assign it (see also §2.3.2).

```
def f(b):
    x = 1
    if b:
        x = 2
    else:
        pass
    return x  # error
```

```
def f(b):
    if b:
        x = 1
        x = 2
    else:
        x = 1
        pass
    return x  # ok
```

Context operations $\cdot$ and $\oplus$ lift to a right semiring over result types R, with $\mathsf{Assigns}\ \varnothing$ as left and right unit for $\cdot$ and $\mathsf{Returns}$ as unit for $\oplus$ and zero for $\cdot$.

Definition 2 (Override and merge on result types)**.**

$$\begin{aligned} \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \oplus \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta' &= \mathsf{Assigns}\ (\Delta \oplus \Delta') \\ R \oplus \mathsf{Returns} = \mathsf{Returns} \oplus R &= R \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned} \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \cdot \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta' &= \mathsf{Assigns}\ (\Delta \cdot \Delta') \\ R \cdot \mathsf{Returns} = \mathsf{Returns} \cdot R &= \mathsf{Returns} \end{aligned}$$

The $\mathsf{Returns} \cdot R$ case never arises because the well-formedness judgement prohibits unreachable statements (§2.3.5).

Lemma 2 (Right distributivity)**.**

$$(R \oplus R') \cdot S = (R \cdot S) \oplus (R' \cdot S)$$

$$
\begin{array}{rcll}
s & ::= & \texttt{pass} & \text{(Pass)} \\
& | & x = e & \text{(Assign)} \\
& | & s_1\ s_2 & \text{(Seq)} \\
& | & \texttt{return} & \text{(ReturnNone)} \\
& | & \texttt{return}\ e & \text{(Return)} \\
& | & \texttt{if}\ e\texttt{:}\ s\ \texttt{elif}\ e_1\texttt{:}\ s_1\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_n\texttt{:}\ s_n & \text{(If)} \\
& | & \texttt{if}\ e\texttt{:}\ s\ \texttt{elif}\ e_1\texttt{:}\ s_1\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_n\texttt{:}\ s_n\ \texttt{else}\texttt{:}\ s' & \text{(IfElse)} \\
& | & \texttt{def}\ f(\vec{x})\texttt{:}\ s & \text{(Def)} \\
\\
e & ::= & x & \text{(Var)} \\
& | & n & \text{(Literal)} \\
& | & e(\vec{e}) & \text{(Call)} \\
& | & \{\vec{x : e}\} & \text{(Dict)} \\
& | & e.x & \text{(Lookup)} \\
& | & e[e'] & \text{(Subscript)} \\
& | & e \odot e' & \text{(BinOp)} \\
& | & e_1\ \texttt{if}\ e\ \texttt{else}\ e_2 & \text{(CondExpr)} \\
& | & [\vec{e}] & \text{(List)} \\
& | & [\, e\ \vec{q}] & \text{(ListComp)} \\
& | & \texttt{lambda}\ \vec{x}\texttt{:}\ e & \text{(Lambda)} \\
\\
q & ::= & \texttt{if}\ e & \text{(Guard)} \\
& | & \texttt{for}\ x\ \texttt{in}\ e & \text{(Generator)} \\
\\
b & ::= & \mathsf{tt} & \text{(Definitely assigned)} \\
& | & \mathsf{ff} & \text{(Not definitely assigned)} \\
\\
\Gamma, \Delta & ::= & \{\vec{x : b}\} & \\
\\
R, S & ::= & \mathsf{Returns} & \\
& | & \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta &
\end{array}
$$

Figure 1: Syntax of statements, expressions and contexts

2.2 Well-formedness

Local variables. The function $\mathrm{assigns}(s)$ collects the set of variables assigned anywhere in a statement s, without descending into nested function definitions (which have their own scope). If s : Assigns Δ, then $\mathrm{assigns}(s) = \mathrm{dom}(\Delta)$; assigns is a syntactic approximation needed to set up the context before checking s.

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathrm{assigns}(\texttt{pass}) &= \varnothing \\
\mathrm{assigns}(x = e) &= \{x\} \\
\mathrm{assigns}(s_1\ s_2) &= \mathrm{assigns}(s_1) \cup \mathrm{assigns}(s_2) \\
\mathrm{assigns}(\texttt{return}) &= \varnothing \\
\mathrm{assigns}(\texttt{return}\ e) &= \varnothing \\
\mathrm{assigns}(\texttt{if}\ e_1 :\ s_1\ \texttt{elif}\ e_2 :\ s_2\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_{n+1} :\ s_{n+1}) &= \mathrm{assigns}(\vec{s}) \\
\mathrm{assigns}(\texttt{if}\ e_1 :\ s_1\ \texttt{elif}\ e_2 :\ s_2\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_{n+1} :\ s_{n+1}\ \texttt{else}:\ s_{n+2}) &= \mathrm{assigns}(\vec{s}) \\
\mathrm{assigns}(\texttt{def}\ f(\vec{x}) :\ s) &= \{f\}
\end{aligned}$$

Captured variables. The function $\mathrm{captures}(s)$ collects the set of variables from the enclosing scope that are captured by a closure (lambda or nested function definition) within s:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathrm{captures}(\texttt{pass}) &= \varnothing \\
\mathrm{captures}(x = e) &= \mathrm{captures}(e) \\
\mathrm{captures}(s_1\ s_2) &= \mathrm{captures}(s_1) \cup \mathrm{captures}(s_2) \\
\mathrm{captures}(\texttt{return}) &= \varnothing \\
\mathrm{captures}(\texttt{return}\ e) &= \mathrm{captures}(e) \\
\mathrm{captures}(\texttt{if}\ e_1 :\ s_1\ \texttt{elif}\ e_2 :\ s_2\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_{n+1} :\ s_{n+1}) &= \mathrm{captures}(\vec{e}) \cup \mathrm{captures}(\vec{s}) \\
\mathrm{captures}(\texttt{if}\ e_1 :\ s_1\ \texttt{elif}\ e_2 :\ s_2\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_{n+1} :\ s_{n+1}\ \texttt{else}:\ s_{n+2}) &= \mathrm{captures}(\vec{e}) \cup \mathrm{captures}(\vec{s}) \\
\mathrm{captures}(\texttt{def}\ f(\vec{x}) :\ s) &= \mathrm{fv}(s) \setminus (\{\vec{x}\} \cup \mathrm{assigns}(s))
\end{aligned}$$

The function extends to expressions in the obvious way, with the following interesting cases:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathrm{captures}(x) &= \varnothing \\
\mathrm{captures}(\texttt{lambda}\ \vec{x}\texttt{:}\ e) &= \mathrm{fv}(e) \setminus \{\vec{x}\}
\end{aligned}$$

Well-formedness judgement. Every well-formed statement either *definitely returns*, or *definitely assigns* a set of variables Δ, which may be empty. The base cases are that `return e` definitely returns, and `x = e` definitely assigns $\{\texttt{x}\}$.

2.3 Examples

2.3.1 Assignment as definition

Although PurePy is pure and all variable usage is well-scoped, local variables are introduced using an *assignment statement*, for compatibility with Python. If a variable is definitely assigned in any branch of a conditional, then for that variable to be usable after the conditional, every other branch of the conditional must either definitely return, or definitely assign that variable too. Thus the following are both well-formed:

$\Gamma \vdash s : R$

pass

$$\frac{}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{pass} : \mathsf{Assigns}\ \varnothing}$$

assign

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash e \qquad x \notin \mathrm{captures}(e)}{\Gamma \vdash x = e : \mathsf{Assigns}\ \{x : \mathsf{tt}\}}$$

return-none

$$\frac{}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{return} : \mathsf{Returns}}$$

return

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash e}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{return}\ e : \mathsf{Returns}}$$

seq

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash s_1 : \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \qquad \Gamma \cdot \Delta \vdash s_2 : R \qquad \mathrm{captures}(s_1) \cap \mathrm{assigns}(s_2) = \varnothing}{\Gamma \vdash s_1\ s_2 : \mathsf{Assigns}\ \Delta \cdot R}$$

if

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash \vec{e} \qquad \Gamma \vdash \vec{s} : \vec{R}}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{if}\ e_1 :\ s_1\ \texttt{elif}\ e_2 :\ s_2\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_{n+1} :\ s_{n+1} : R_1 \oplus \ldots R_{n+1} \oplus \ldots \oplus \mathsf{Assigns}\ \varnothing}$$

if-else

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash \vec{e} \qquad \Gamma \vdash \vec{s} : \vec{R}}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{if}\ e_1 :\ s_1\ \texttt{elif}\ e_2 :\ s_2\ \cdots\ \texttt{elif}\ e_{n+1} :\ s_{n+1}\ \texttt{else} :\ s_{n+2} : R_1 \oplus \cdots \oplus R_{n+2}}$$

def

$$\frac{\Gamma, x_1 : \mathsf{tt}, \ldots, x_n : \mathsf{tt}, \mathrm{assigns}(s) : \mathsf{ff} \vdash s : R \qquad f \notin \mathrm{captures}(\texttt{def}\ f(\vec{x}) :\ s)}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{def}\ f(\vec{x}) :\ s : \mathsf{Assigns}\ \{f : \mathsf{tt}\}}$$

(a) Statement s is well-formed in Γ

$\Gamma \vdash e$

$$\frac{\Gamma(x) = \mathsf{tt}}{\Gamma \vdash x}\ \textsc{var} \qquad\qquad \frac{\Gamma, x_1 : \mathsf{tt}, \ldots, x_n : \mathsf{tt} \vdash e}{\Gamma \vdash \texttt{lambda}\ \vec{x} \texttt{:}\ e}\ \textsc{lambda}$$

(b) Expression e is well-formed in Γ

```
if a < b:
   comp = "smaller"
else:
   comp = "bigger"
return comp
```

```
if a < b:
   return "smaller"
else:
   comp = "bigger"
return comp
```

The definite assignment set for a conditional that has at least one branch which definitely assigns is calculated by merging the definite assignment sets for all branches which definitely assign, using the $\oplus$ operator on environments.

2.3.2 Local assignment in conditional clauses

For flexibility, we permit *branch-local* variables. The assignment of `x` below (left) is permitted, and can be used locally in that branch of the conditional:

```
def foo():
  z = 6
  if b:
    x = 3
    y = x + 1
  else:
    y = 0
  return z
```

(a) Branch-local definition of `x`

```
def foo():
  x = 6
  if b:
    x = 3
    y = x + 1
  else:
    y = 0
  return x # error: partially defined
```

(b) Now with use of `x` after the conditional

However such variables only appear to be branch-local. The definition of $\oplus$ actually ensures that a variable assigned in any branch is considered assigned by the conditional; however unless it is assigned in *every* branch that does not definitely return, it will be bound to ff in the corresponding environment. Any attempt to refer to such a variable is illegal, as it refers to a variable which may not be assigned. (Thus the right-hand program is ill-formed, despite the enclosing `x = 6`, because in the `return x` statement, the inner assignment shadows the the outer one, and the inner assignment is only partial.) If we were to allow the program on the right, there would be no straightforward way to assign it a semantics which is both pure, and in agreement with Python, since in Python the function returns `3` in the case where `b` is `True`.

2.3.3 Function-level scoping of local variables

In Python, all local variables are scoped to the entire function body, not just from the point of assignment onwards. The assigns function in the `def` rule reflects this: all variables assigned anywhere in the function body are introduced at ff before the body is checked. This means the following program is statically rejected by PurePy, whereas Python rejects it at runtime with an `UnboundLocalError`:

```
y = 7

def f():
```

```
    x = y  # error: y is local (due to assignment below)
    y = 8

f()
```

Because `y` appears on the left-hand side of an assignment in `f`, it is in $\mathrm{assigns}(s)$ for the body of `f`, and is therefore introduced at ff at the top of the function. The reference to `y` in `x = y` then fails the well-formedness check, since $\Gamma(\mathtt{y}) = \mathsf{ff}$ rather than $\Gamma(\mathtt{y}) = \mathsf{tt}$.

2.3.4 Shadowing of captured variables

Once a variable has been captured by a closure, it cannot be reassigned in the enclosing scope, because its Python semantics would depend on mutation. Consider the following program:

```
def f():
    x = 5
    def g():
        return x
    x = 6
    return x + g()
```

In Python, `g` closes over the *mutable binding* of `x`, so `g()` returns `6` and the result is `12`. In a pure semantics where `x = 6` shadows the earlier binding, `g()` would return `5` and the result would be `11`. To preserve agreement with a subset of Python, we exclude this program from PurePy: the side condition in the seq rule requires that no variable captured by s_1 is reassigned by s_2. Here `x` is captured by the definition of `g` and reassigned by `x = 6`, so the program is rejected. This is analogous to Java's requirement that local variables captured by a lambda must be *effectively final* [7, §15.27.2]: local variables are allocated on the stack, and so only the value of a local variable can be captured by a closure.

The same issue arises when a variable is captured and reassigned in the *same* statement:

```
x = 5
def x():
    return x
x()  # Python: returns the function (late binding); pure: returns 5
```

To preserve agreement with Python until such time as recursion is supported, side conditions on the assign and def rules reject programs like this, requiring that the variable being bound is not captured by the expression or function body respectively.

2.3.5 Unreachable code

A non-empty sequence of statements returns only if the last statement returns, and all preceding statements assign. Thus the following is illegal:

```
def foo(x):
  return x + 1
  return x    # error: unreachable
```

2.3.6 Conditionals without `else` clauses

An `if` statement without an `else` clause is equivalent to an `if` statement with an `else` clause whose body is a `pass` statement; such a statement never returns.

2.3.7 Implicit `None`

A `return` statement without an expression is equivalent to `return None`.

2.3.8 Implicit `return`

A function whose body s assigns rather than returns is equivalent to a function whose body is s followed by `return None`. This ensures every function returns, even if it is not explicitly specified.

3 Operational semantics

For a statement s, the result $\mathsf{assigns}\ \rho$ represents *normal completion* of s, with accumulated environment ρ; the result $\mathsf{returns}\ v$ represents *abrupt completion* of s with return value v. Composing statements sequentially composes their results according to the following partial monoid, analogous to sequential composition of result types:

$$\mathsf{assigns}\ \rho \cdot \mathsf{assigns}\ \rho' = \mathsf{assigns}\ (\rho \cdot \rho')$$
$$\mathsf{assigns}\ \rho \cdot \mathsf{returns}\ v = \mathsf{returns}\ v$$

with $\mathsf{assigns}\ \varnothing$ as left and right unit. Function definitions delimit the scope of these effects, so as black boxes functions are always pure.

4 Related work

Subsets of programming languages have been defined for various purposes in the research literature:

Even though the syntax of programming languages if often described precisely, essentially none of the languages in mainstream use today formally define their behaviour. Therefore, various well-defined subsets of programming languages were constructed to equip languages with formal (often even mechanised) semantics. Examples of this include work on Java [10], OCaml [25], JavaScript [5, 8, 20, 21], PHP [6], Rust [12, 13], and even lower-level languages and intermediate representations such as WebAssembly [29, 30, 31] and LLVM-IR [32, 33]. A particular success story of this line of work is the formalisation of a substantial subset of the C programming language, called Clight [4], which lead to the development of a verified compiler [17]. In a similar manner, the CakeML project [15] produced a verified implementation of a fragment of the ML language [18], based on previous efforts [16] of mechanising its semantics. Previous work on formalising the semantics of Python include an embedding [9] within the $\mathbb{K}$ semantics framework [24], a definition of structural operational semantics [14], and a reduction of most of the language to a core calculus [22].

A different line of work concerns the delineation of language subsets for a particular purpose. A prominent example is the *Source* family of languages [3], which are progressively extended subsets of JavaScript specifically geared towards introducing first-year computer science students to the foundations of computing. It is based on a new edition of a classic introductory text book [1], in which all

$$
\begin{array}{lcll}
v & ::= & n & \text{(Literal)} \\
 & | & \langle \rho, \vec{x}, s \rangle & \text{(Closure)} \\
\rho & ::= & \{x \mapsto v\} & \text{(Environment)} \\
r & ::= & \mathsf{assigns}\ \rho & \\
 & | & \mathsf{returns}\ v &
\end{array}
$$

(a) Values, environments and evaluation results

$s \Rightarrow r$

eval-pass

$$\frac{}{\rho, \texttt{pass} \Rightarrow \mathsf{assigns}\ \{\varnothing\}}$$

eval-assign

$$\frac{\rho, e \Rightarrow v}{\rho, x = e \Rightarrow \mathsf{assigns}\ \{x \mapsto v\}}$$

eval-return

$$\frac{\rho, e \Rightarrow v}{\rho, \texttt{return}\ e \Rightarrow \mathsf{returns}\ v}$$

eval-seq

$$\frac{\rho, s_1 \Rightarrow r \qquad \rho \cdot \rho_1, s_2 \Rightarrow r'}{\rho, s_1\ s_2 \Rightarrow r \cdot r'}$$

eval-def

$$\frac{}{\rho, \texttt{def}\ f(\vec{x}) :\ s \Rightarrow \mathsf{assigns}\ \{f \mapsto \langle \rho, \vec{x}, s \rangle\}}$$

Figure 5: Statement evaluation

$\rho, e \Rightarrow v$

$$\frac{}{\rho, x \Rightarrow \rho(x)}\ \textsc{var} \qquad \frac{}{\rho, \texttt{lambda}\ \vec{x}\texttt{:}\ e \Rightarrow \langle \rho, \vec{x}, \texttt{return}\ e \rangle}\ \textsc{lambda}$$

$$\frac{\rho, e \Rightarrow \langle \rho', \vec{x}, s \rangle \qquad \rho, \vec{e}' \Rightarrow \vec{v} \qquad \rho' \cdot \{x \mapsto v\}, s \Rightarrow \mathsf{returns}\ v'}{\rho, e(\vec{e}') \Rightarrow v'}\ \textsc{call}$$

Figure 6: Expression evaluation

program examples (which had previously been in Scheme) are illustrated in JavaScript. By successively increasing the allowed language fragment with each chapter (corresponding to different versions of the Source language), it allows to put focus on the particular aspects the authors are trying to convey, while disallowing students with prior knowledge of programming to take short-cuts by utilising more complex language features. The authors of [3] also remark, that the choice of JavaScript as a language was a pragmatic one: A previous study [26] showed that *industrial relevance* is perceived as the second-most important factor in choosing a programming language for introductory courses by educators in Australiasia and the UK.

Likewise, various subsets of Python have been defined for different purposes in the past. ChocoPy [19] describes a subset specifically defined as a source language for the final project in courses on compiler construction, as most students are already familiar with the Python language by the time they take such a course. By restricting the language to a statically typed fragment, most student compilers can produce code that usually even outperforms the CPython reference interpreter. In a similar manner, Restricted Python (RPython) [2] was defined as a strictly typed subset of Python, which removes some of the more dynamic features of the language. As part of the PyPy project [23], this allows RPython to be more easily compiled to common language runtimes, such as JVM and CLI/.NET.

We are aware of only one other work [27] specifically targetting a functional subset of Python, with the express intent of using it as a teaching tool. While we share a similar goal, our language fragment encloses more of the overall Python language, as their work doesn't allow for control structures such as conditionals or loops.

While it is not our goal to change Python towards a more functional programming language, it is interesting to notice that there are movements within the Python community for inclusion of programming principles commonly found in functional languages. An example of this is the inclusion of *lambda expressions* already in Python 1.0, and a more recent PEP draft [11] advocating for *deeply immutable objects*.

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